FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

In less than a month from now, India will start voting to elect its next national government. Naturally, it's a time of intense deliberation, stock-taking and thoughts for the future. It is a happy coincidence that we were able to plug into this mood with the India Today Conclave 2024. The timing proved particularly fortuitous, for a whole galaxy of eminent personages found it an apt moment to tune their words to the pre-electoral scenario. Among those who took the stage were Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who made his first full speech after the election dates were announced. But politics did not exhaust the canvas. Beyond top Indian government and Opposition figures, the roster included another prime minister, top economists and business czars, authorities on strategic affairs, military and foreign policy, a neuroscientist cum economist, one of the world's greatest contemporary architects, a TV host-comedian who manages to be contrarian and yet globally viral, a bunch of amazing achievers from India's hinterland, Bollywood stars and sporting sensations, besides, of course, one of India's most well-known spiritual gurus. The ideation, therefore, was on an eclectic plane and frequently filled with revelatory insights.

This year, we hosted the 21st edition of the India Today Conclave. When we first envisaged it, as an annual festival of ideas, the millennium had just turned. It was a time when the world was brimming over with a strong sense of futurism. The calendar itself evoked such a feeling at the dawn of the 21st century. The Internet was still in its infancy, and a newly connected world had filled us with a surge of technological optimism. Now, as the conclave hits adulthood, so to speak, we again stand on the edge of a paradigm shift. Alongside our journey, digital technologies, too, have attained their next stage of maturation. Artificial Intelligence beckons us to a future we could not have imagined 21 years ago. This is the theme I tried to develop in my opening address, with five ideas on how to convert the 'India Moment' we are living in into a full-fledged 'India Movement'. That entails taking basic, doable steps to create the India of our dreams—not just an economic giant by sheer numbers, but a truly Great Nation with equal access to life choices and dignity across the board.



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What I found heartening was that this future orientation was a common sentiment among all speakers. The most dramatic, if light-hearted, enunciation of it came as the Prime Minister rebutted me on stage. That he is a leader whose signature style is to think on a grand scale—and in the long term—is a universally known fact. So I asked him, during my brief introduction, whether, considering his frequent visits to the South, and his propensity to think long term, he was in fact campaigning for the 2029 election, not the one in 2024. In his smiling riposte, he said: "Aroonji, set your whole team to find out: *'Ki Modi hai kya* (what is Modi)?' You have got stuck at 2029? Here I am thinking of 2047!" His address was perfectly in sync with that. It blended, in equal parts, an appraisal of the past decade of governance and a forward-looking vision statement. Both are umbilically linked. For, the specific ways in which India has experienced development will be key to its future. For instance, the PM said, India's start-up economy is not to be measured in terms of its overall numbers but the fact that it has already touched 600-plus districts and is no longer restricted to hubs like Bengaluru. That speaks of an expansion of capacities, which should be the crux of the idea of Viksit Bharat.

It's as if Modi's grand mental template is infectious. Union home minister Amit Shah, embedded deeply in the strategic calculus of everyday politics, was sharp, astute and combative as ever, speaking on a range of controversial questions the Indian public is exercised over: electoral bonds, the Citizenship Amendment Act, One Nation One Poll and the BJP's aggressive tactics vis-à-vis Opposition parties. S. Jaishankar, gently parrying questions on his virality, conceded: "Being the foreign minister of the Modi government sets your behavioural approach." Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, too, built up from a keen nuts-and-bolts realism to the objective of becoming a $7 trillion economy by 2030. Between them and Chief of Defence Staff Gen. Anil Chauhan, a picture emerged of India's emerging global position. Sessions on evolving multilateral equations—around the Indo-Pacific vis-à-vis China, via India's membership of the Quad, and a war-ridden landscape elsewhere—deepened its strategic basis.

Sessions that went beyond old-style politics came like dizzying, exhilarating excursions to the future. Is it a good idea for humans to get brain implants that connect us to the Internet? Moran Cerf, neuroscientist and business professor, was true to both his callings as he laid out both the promise and the apocalyptic dangers. Among them, simply, that you can be hacked. What has India learnt from the bruising Covid experience and is it prepared for Disease X? On call was economist-epidemiologist Ramanan Laxminarayan, with his sobering views on "evolution at work". Can we play god with AI? Vyshak Venugopalan and Samik Roy, old hands from Adobe and Microsoft, leaned in. How should we think about the equity market in 2047? Investor Jim Rogers had the answers.

A most alluring vision of the future came alive on stage not with regard to India, though. It was tiny Bhutan dreaming big, in line with its concept of Gross National Happiness. Prime Minister Tshering Tobgay asked the audience to imagine a neo-city, utterly in sync with both nature and culture. One that integrates all human needs, including the need for beauty and spiritual repose, all this while being carbon neutral. What world-renowned Danish architect Bjarke Ingels then etched out on the big screen was a 1,000 square kilometre Xanadu for the 21st century. Clusters of elegant sloped-roof dwellings interspersed by paddy terraces, giant cultural commons, bridges turned into public buildings, all made of local timber and speaking the local architectural dialect on a grand scale, right down to a swanky airport and a dam that looks like a work of art. Between and around them, continuous mountain forest—real nature, with rivers and wildlife corridors unmolested by human presence. It is called 'mindfulness city'. Maybe the whole world needs to be like Bhutan.

(Aroon Purie)